

sa

SUMMER 2024

Homeschooling

and beyond

**Top concerns
keeping parents
up at night**

**MATRIC
FINALS**

Success &
recovery

**COOKING &
BONDING**

Fun & festive
holiday treats

**SCREEN
TIME AND
CHILDREN**

Google unveils
School Time

**Supporting
gifted children**

**UNLOCKING
CREATIVITY AND
CONFIDENCE**

The power of independent play

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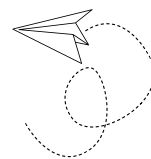
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SUGGESTED DATES



2025

4-TERM SCHOOLS

August

Sunday	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday
					1	2
3	4 Maths	5 Eng	6 Afr	7 LS LO	8 LS CA	9
10	11 Soc.Sci	12 Nat. Sci &Tech	13 Tech	14 Gen.Kn Bible S	15 Robot E.M.S	16

2025

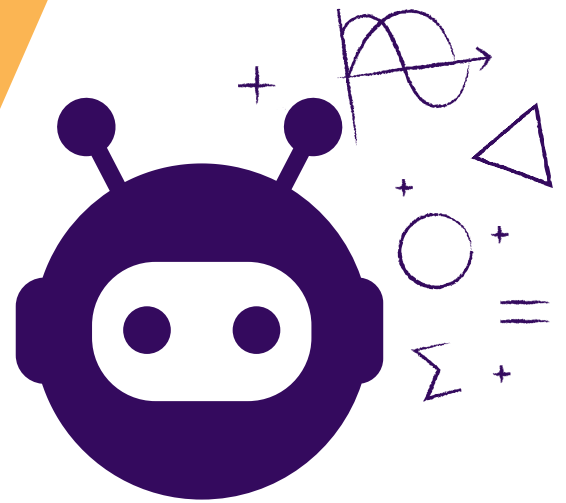
3-TERM SCHOOLS

September

Sunday	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday
	1 Maths	2 Eng	3 Afr	4 LS LO	5 LS CA	6
7	8 Soc.Sci	9 Nat. Sci &Tech	10 Tech	11 Gen.Kn Bible S	12 Robot E.M.S	13



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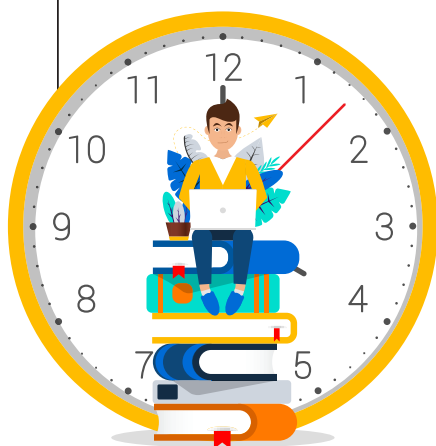
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I often find myself wishing for the future, as a person and as a parent. I think the minds of even the most present parents sometimes wander forward.

Once our children are born, we're excited and can't wait for each new milestone – when they roll over, when they sit, their first words, their first steps. Thereafter, we're excited for them to start activities, school or their first visit to a friend's house. Then we anticipate their first summer job and when they can drive themselves to their friends and activities. With every

milestone, they become a little more independent – and I can't help feeling a tinge of sadness that yet another hallmark of their childhood is ending.

As my youngest fell asleep on my lap last night, I realised that his legs have grown so long that they're dangling off me and almost touching the floor. His face has also changed: he's losing his baby chubbiness and his features are increasingly resembling my husband's. Time has taken my baby away and replaced him with a toddler.

When you have kids, everyone tells you to enjoy each moment, because time flies. Aware of how true that is, I hug them a little longer and stare at them while they're playing, trying to soak them in. I know that one day, when just my husband and I are in a quiet, half-empty house, I'll be glad I did so. However, I also remind myself that kids are meant to leave the nest at some stage. They're living their one, wild and precious life – and we

get to watch them grow and reach maturity.

Remember, hard as it may be to let go of the little ones you adore, their growing up isn't something to dread. It's our most cherished hope.

With the end of the year and the holiday season fast approaching, the *SA Homeschooling & Beyond* team wishes you a happy and safe festive season. We hope your holidays are filled with warmth, peace and joy.

Adri



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Matric finals: Success and recovery

With matric final exams in full swing, it's natural to feel the pressure, regardless of your level of preparation

For most pupils, the next few weeks are mostly dotting i's and crossing t's as they write the final assessments of their school careers. Many other pupils, however, will be at their wits' end, afraid that no matter how much time they put in, they won't do as well as they hoped. Some may even need to

come to terms with the prospect of failing one or more subjects, leaving them with elevated levels of anxiety and uncertainty about the road ahead.

"Whether you're struggling with one or two subjects or feeling overwhelmed by the entire exam experience, it's important to take a breath and honestly evaluate your situation. There's still time to ensure you do as well as possible, where you can, while setting your mind at ease that there are pathways to success after the exams, should some of your fears be realised," says

Dingaane Moropane, Acting Deputy Dean: Teaching and Learning at IIE Rosebank College.



"The roads to success are many and varied – and a roadblock or diversion should be seen as only temporary."



He says students should avoid catastrophising their situation and adopt a strategic mindset instead.

"Concentrate on maximising your performance in the subjects where you feel confident. Allocate sufficient study time to reinforce your understanding and excel in those areas. Simultaneously, create a targeted plan for the subjects you're concerned about. Identify weak points,





seek additional help and accept that a rewrite might be necessary,” he says.

“If it becomes evident that you may not clear the hurdle in certain subjects, acceptance and resilience will stand you in good stead at this stage. Of course, it’s important that you continue to try your best. However, investing too much emotional energy in potential disappointment down the line will affect your overall performance, not only your performance in your weak areas,” says Moropane.

It’s therefore essential to remember that you can rewrite the subject/s next year and have enough time to improve your performance substantially.

“While giving your best, mentally prepare for the possibility of a rewrite. Accept that it’s not the end of the world if things don’t go perfectly to plan. Stay resilient and focused on improvement. Shift your



attention to performing as well as possible in your strong subjects, rather than dwelling only on the ones in which you’re weaker.”

Even if things don’t go as originally planned, there are always different options and alternative pathways on the road to success.

“Matric exams are an important milestone in your educational journey, but they’re not the final word on your potential or prospects. The roads to success are many and varied – and a roadblock or diversion should be seen as only temporary, as well as an opportunity to regroup, reflect and re-strategise,” says Moropane.

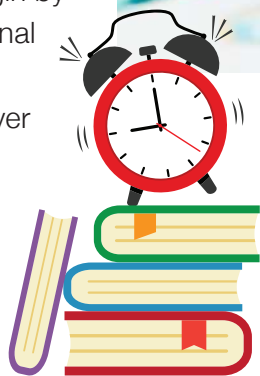
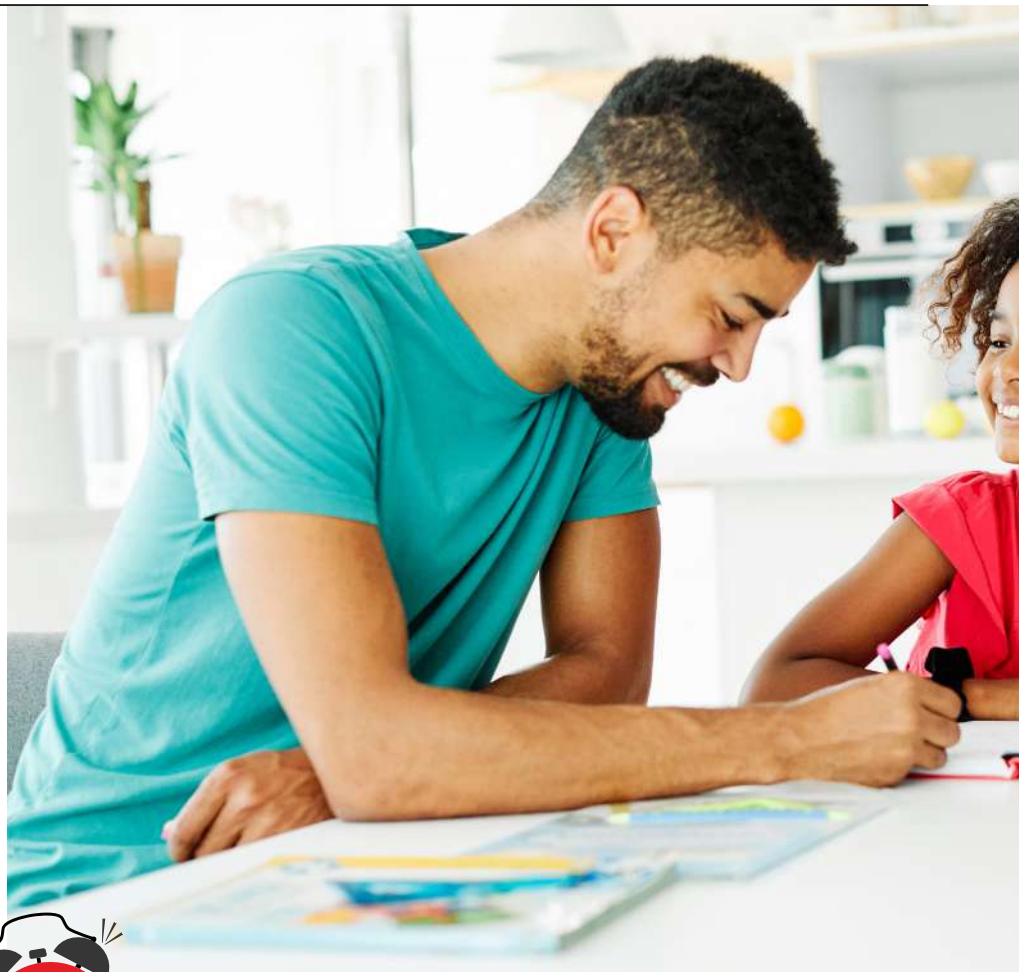


Homeschooling offers flexibility and personalised learning, but creating an effective daily schedule is crucial for success

Are you wondering how to go about creating a daily homeschooling schedule that works for you? Here are some practical tips from Impaq to help craft a daily routine that maximises their potential. Let's make sure you're not just faffing, dawdling or procrastinating, but taking your education to the next level!

1 Start with a plan Begin by outlining your educational goals. Identify the subjects and topics you need to cover and set realistic short- and long-term objectives. This will give your schedule direction and purpose, helping you avoid the infamous "I'll do it just now" syndrome.

2 Set consistent wake-up times Establish a regular wake-up time to create a sense of normality and structure. A



Tips for creating a daily schedule for studying

consistent start to the day helps your body clock adjust, making it easier to stay alert and focused during learning sessions. No sleeping in until mid-morning!

3 Designate studying hours Block out specific hours for studying each day. Align these with your peak productivity times – some pupils are more alert in the morning, while others perform better in the afternoon. Consistent learning hours foster discipline and routine, so you don't end up skiving off.

4 Incorporate breaks Breaks are essential for maintaining focus and preventing burnout. Implement short breaks between study sessions and a longer break





for lunch. Use this time to relax, stretch and recharge. Remember, even a quick TikTok trend dance session can be a *joy* that gives you revitalised energy to carry on studying!

5 Create a dedicated studying space Set up a specific area in your home or room for studying. This space should be free from distractions and equipped with all the necessary materials. A dedicated learning environment can enhance concentration and productivity. Find a spot that's superior for studying, not just a place to plonk down.

6 Balance studying with extracurricular activities Include time for hobbies and other interests in your schedule. Balancing studying with extracurricular activities promotes a well-rounded education and supports mental well-being. Whether it's soccer, swimming, cycling, yoga or rugby practice, it's all part of the plan. Daily physical activity is crucial for maintaining health and well-being. It boosts energy levels and improves concentration.

7 Utilise online resources Leverage Impaq's online articles and homeschooling resources. These tools can provide additional support and enrichment for your studies.

“Let's make sure you're not just faffing, dawdling or procrastinating, but taking your education to the next level!”

Stay updated with the latest educational content to enhance your studying experience. It's like having your own personal teacher on standby. In fact, you can ask for extra help online or consider online school with a real teacher, if you prefer.

8 Plan for Flexibility While a routine is important, it's also essential to be flexible. Life can be unpredictable and sometimes you'll need to adjust your schedule. Allow for flexibility to accommodate unforeseen events and ensure a balanced approach to studying. After all, sometimes things go a bit haywire – and that's OK.

9 Review and adjust Regularly review your schedule to see what is and isn't working. Make adjustments as needed to optimise your routine. Involve your parents or guardians in this process for additional insights and support. It's all about keeping things tight, but fun.



The power of independent play

Encouraging children to play independently fosters essential life skills and prepares them for future challenges. It's a beautiful way to nurture their creativity and confidence

As parents, we all remember those moments from our childhood, lost in a world of make-believe with our toys, following our own lead. Independent play offers that same magical experience for young explorers today – and the benefits go far beyond just keeping them occupied. It's about nurturing their creativity, confidence, problem-solving skills and independence – all of which are crucial for their development.

While playing with others is also essential in teaching interactive, collaborative and social skills, independent play is about teaching children to explore their own imaginations and preoccupy themselves. This is an invaluable



lesson in intellectual self-sustainability and resilience.

Ursula Assis, Country Director of Dibber International Preschools, emphasises further essential aspects of independent play.

“Independent play can sound intimidating to parents who worry that their children will get bored, frustrated or lost along the way. However, independent play isn’t about leaving your child on their own. Children often thrive with a little structured guidance and a safe, stimulating environment that sparks their curiosity and invites them to explore.

“Start by creating a safe and enchanting space that inspires your child’s imagination,” says Assis. “Fill it with a variety of age-appropriate toys and materials that encourage exploration and creativity. This could be a cosy corner of your home transformed

into a mini-adventure land with open-ended toys like blocks, dolls, puzzles and art

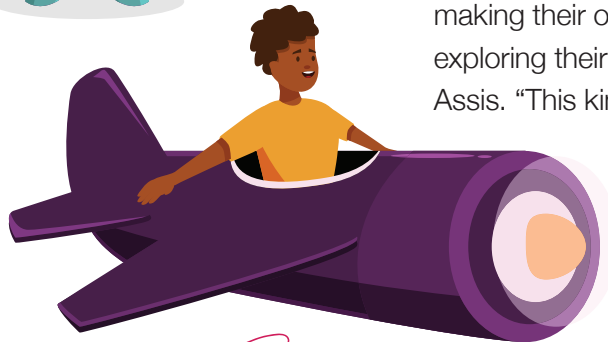
supplies. Rotate the toys and objects periodically to keep things fresh and inspiring.”



Independent play is when your child dives into their world of activities without needing direct help from adults or peers.

“It’s about them taking the lead, entertaining themselves, making their own play decisions and exploring their interests solo,” says

Assis. “This kind of play is vital for their growth, fostering creativity, problem-solving skills, self-reliance and emotional balance.”



As they navigate their play world independently, children learn to trust their own abilities and problem-solving skills. During independent play, they engage in critical thinking, build a sense of autonomy and grow more confident in their abilities. For example, when children build a block tower, they learn to think creatively about preventing it from falling, control their emotions and regulate their behaviour.

“Independent play is a training ground for problem-solving. Playing alone requires children to entertain themselves and think creatively, fostering innovative thinking. Imagine a child trying to fix a toy that isn’t working as expected – this critical thinking is essential for tackling challenges





for entertainment, encouraging them to read a book, draw or invent their own games.

“Independent play also prepares children for school, where they may have to engage socially. It helps with emotional development and self-regulation and enhances their attention span. Additionally, they learn to manage their time, share resources and navigate social interactions.

“While your child takes centre stage during independent play, you’re not completely out of the picture. It’s important to offer encouragement with a simple: ‘Have fun!’ or ‘Wow! That’s a cool tower!’ to show your interest. Let your child know you’re nearby in case they need help, but resist the urge to jump in and solve problems for them,” says Assis.

Having said that, it’s also important not to be intrusive. Children may create a world they prefer to keep secret until they feel ready to talk about it. Respect this and allow your child the privacy they need to explore and control what they’re creating. A child who’s reluctant to start explaining their imaginary characters or spaces may resent being interrogated about it and fear being judged or mocked. Your child’s trust in you will grow even stronger if you give them the freedom and permission to manage their own fantasies until they’re good and ready to share them.

now and in the future. Playing independently also allows children to explore their emotions and experiment with different ways of expressing themselves in a safe space. Acting out a story with toys can help them process feelings of frustration or sadness, teaching them valuable emotional regulation skills.”

One of the most delightful benefits of independent play is that it taps into children’s creativity and imagination. They can be superheroes, doctors or astronauts within their play space, seeing the world from different perspectives and thinking creatively about solving problems.

“By fostering a child’s ability to play independently, parents and caregivers can support their growth and development meaningfully.”



“Independent play is essential for building self-confidence. As children navigate their play world on their own, they discover their talents and interests. Imagine the pride on a child’s face when they complete a puzzle all by themselves or create a masterpiece with their crayons. In today’s fast-paced world, it’s more important than ever for children to learn how to entertain themselves. Independent play reduces their reliance on screens





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**ASK
DALENA**

Kelly Eyre, Quality and Pedagogy Lead at Dibber International Preschools, explores the top concerns keeping South African parents of children under six awake and offers insights and advice to ease those fears

Top concerns keeping parents up at night

As the world quiets down and little ones drift off to sleep, many parents find themselves in the glow of their screens, typing out their latest concerns and questions. The age of instant information has made it easy for parents to seek answers in the middle of the night.

Developmental milestones

Every parent wonders whether their child's on track with their development. From their first words to taking their first steps,

concerns about whether a child's meeting milestones can be overwhelming. Parents often compare their children's progress with those of others, which can fuel anxiety, especially when extended family or community members express concern.



It's crucial to remember that every child develops at their own pace and there's a wide range of what's considered normal. However, if you're concerned about your child's development, it's important to consult professionals, including paediatricians, early childhood educators and therapists. Teachers and managers of

schools and early childhood centres can also provide valuable insights into your child's progress and suggest activities to support their development at home.

Health and nutrition

In South Africa, where access to healthcare can vary widely, parents may worry about whether their children are getting the right nutrients or are healthy. Concerns often centre around ensuring a balanced diet, understanding the importance of specific nutrients and knowing how to handle common childhood illnesses, like colds or fevers. South African parents may also face challenges related to food security and access to nutritious foods. It's essential to offer a variety of foods and encourage healthy eating habits from an early age. Consulting healthcare professionals, such as paediatricians and nutritionists, can provide reassurance and guidance. Understanding the local healthcare system and having access to emergency services or local clinics can also help parents manage health concerns more effectively.



Education and learning

With the country's diverse education system, parents often worry about giving their children a good start. Questions about the best early childhood education options, how to encourage a love of learning and whether they're doing enough at home are common. SA's unique blend of public, private and homeschooling options can make this decision even more complex. To support your child's early education, consider engaging with teachers and school administrators to understand the curriculum and how you can complement learning at home. Creating a stimulating environment through educational toys, books and interactive play can also nurture a love of learning. Remember, the goal is

to foster a supportive learning environment that encourages curiosity and exploration, regardless of the formal schooling path chosen.

Behavioural issues

Tantrums, picky eating, bullying and bedtime struggles can cause sleepless nights for many parents. These common behavioural issues often lead



parents to search for solutions and advice, rather than resorting to harsh discipline. Finding a balanced approach can be challenging in South Africa, where different cultural norms and parenting styles exist. Positive parenting techniques, such as using time-outs, setting clear boundaries and offering choices, can help manage these behaviours. Understanding developmental stages and the reasons for certain behaviours can also provide context and reduce frustration. Engaging with professionals, including paediatricians and child psychologists, can offer strategies tailored to your child's needs. Additionally, teachers and caregivers can provide insights into your child's behaviour in different settings and suggest consistent

approaches across home and school environments.

Safety concerns

In a country with diverse social and economic landscapes, safety is a top priority for parents. Concerns often include child-proofing the home, road safety, teaching children about stranger danger and personal safety. Parents may also worry about neighbourhood safety, access to safe play areas and emergency preparedness. To address these concerns, parents can take practical steps such as installing safety gates, securing hazardous items and teaching children basic safety rules, like not talking to strangers (or accepting lifts or sweets from them) and understanding emergency contact information. Additionally, it's beneficial to

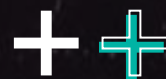


familiarise yourself with local safety resources and community support systems, including neighbourhood watches and emergency services. Schools and early childhood centres often have safety protocols in place, so engaging with teachers and administrators can provide peace of mind and ensure consistent safety practices.

Balancing work and family life

Finding a balance between work and family life can be challenging. Many parents struggle with time management, guilt over not spending enough time with their children and the stress of juggling multiple responsibilities. The country's economic diversity also means that some parents may work long hours or multiple jobs, making this balance even more difficult. To manage these challenges, prioritising tasks and setting realistic expectations is essential. Establishing routines and setting aside dedicated family time can help create stability and foster strong family bonds. Seeking support from extended family, friends or childcare services can alleviate some burdens. Remember that quality time, even in small amounts, can significantly impact your child's well-being and development. Engaging with other parents, joining support groups and accessing local resources can also provide valuable advice and support.





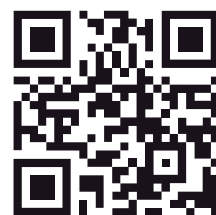
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Ask Dalena



Dalena van der Westhuizen will answer any questions or concerns you may have about learning, concentration, memory and cognitive development – and, of course, the frustrations arising from these

How can I ensure that my child's actually studying and not just pretending?

– *Khevana Theledi*

Hi Khevana

One way to check whether your child's truly studying is by encouraging them to explain what they've studied in their own words. Ask them to "teach" you or someone else. This process reveals how well they understand the material. You can also ask questions that prompt them to think critically about the topic, which will help reinforce their knowledge and clarify any gaps.

How involved should a parent be when it comes to their child's studies? I believe in letting them do it on their own, unless they need my help. However, most of my friends don't take the same approach. – Sharon Terblanche

Hi Sharon

It's great to encourage age-appropriate independence in



your child's learning! Research shows that balancing support with autonomy is beneficial. Offer help as needed, but let your child tackle tasks on their own, where possible. This approach builds confidence and problem-solving skills. Checking in regularly can also help you stay informed and available, allowing you to guide them without taking over.

My child is in Grade 4. He doesn't summarise material when studying, but still does really well. How important is summarising and what should my approach be?
– *Meghan Ward*

Hi Meghan

If your son's doing well, summarising may not yet be essential. However, as he progresses, summarising becomes valuable for processing and retaining larger amounts of



information. Introduce it as a skill over time, perhaps by asking him to create short summaries or explanations of what he's studied. This way, he'll gradually build a habit that will serve him well in higher grades.

If my child's mark on her report card for maths is below the grade average (she's in Grade 3 and isn't being homeschooled), should I consider extra lessons, even though her mark is still above 70%? – *Andrea Nel*

Hi Andrea

If your daughter's marks are above 70%, additional lessons aren't necessary unless she's struggling with certain math concepts or lacks confidence. Consider extra help if you notice ongoing challenges or if she expresses frustration with her work. Regularly reviewing foundational skills can also be beneficial to keep her on track and feeling secure in her maths abilities.

About Dalena

Dalena van der Westhuizen is the co-founder and MD of BrainAbility, a cognitive development specialist, a master brain coach and an internationally certified cognitive coach. She translates the latest international cognitive research and best practice into strategies that can be applied by parents and educators alike.

A mom and a self-confessed chocoholic, Dalena enjoys working with both kids and adults to improve the way their brains process information for better learning, reading and focusing.

Send your questions for Dalena to:
adri@isikhova.co.za.





Landing your first job after uni or college



Thousands of students across South Africa are considering their job hunt and career strategy to ensure that they're able to successfully transition into the world of work, in the context of our extremely competitive employment landscape

"Graduation is rightly seen as the ultimate milestone in a student's life – a triumph after years of hard work and dedication. However, as the cap and gown are hung up, a new challenge looms: entering the world of work," says James Read, Senior Manager at the Independent Institute of Education's Rosebank College.

"The transition from university to starting the job hunt and then landing your first role is daunting, but can be made a little less so if you prepare properly," he adds.



“The time to start preparing for your career isn’t after graduation – it’s now. While your university years are filled with lectures, exams and assignments, they also offer invaluable opportunities to build the foundation for your professional life. Employers today are looking for more than just academic qualifications: they want candidates who’re well-rounded, experienced and ready to contribute from day one – and that’s something you should start working on sooner, rather than later.”

Read says there are various practical ways in which students can ensure they leave university in a stronger position than their peers who’ve only focused on academics. These include:

1 **Gaining practical experience through internships or part-time work**

“One of the most effective ways to prepare for the workforce is by gaining practical experience while at university. Internships, part-time jobs or voluntary work provide hands-on experience, allowing you to apply the knowledge you’ve gained in class to real-world situations. Not only does this bolster your resumé, but it helps you develop essential workplace skills, such as teamwork, communication and problem-solving,” says Read.

In South Africa, many companies offer internship programmes specifically designed for students,



encouraging them to investigate opportunities in their fields.

“These opportunities not only give you a taste of the working world, but can lead to full-time employment after graduation. Even if your part-time job isn’t directly related to your field of study, it teaches you valuable skills and makes for an attractive entry on your CV,” adds Read.

2 **Building a professional network**

Networking is a crucial aspect of career development – and the sooner you start, the better.

“While still a student, take advantage of networking opportunities such as career fairs, industry conferences and university events. Join student organisations, clubs and societies related to your field of study. These groups often have strong connections with industry professionals and they can provide access to mentorship, internships and job opportunities,” advises Read.

It goes without saying that building your professional network online, through platforms such as LinkedIn, is an excellent way of getting noticed by companies and employers you may not necessarily be able to reach in person – yet.

3 Developing a strong personal brand

Your personal brand is the way you present yourself to potential employers and plays a critical role in your career success – particularly when you need to stand out among a sea of candidates. Start by identifying your unique strengths, skills and values. What sets you apart from other candidates? What are your career goals? Once you clearly understand your personal brand, ensure that it's reflected in your resumé, covering letter and online profiles and interactions.

“A solid personal brand is also about consistency. How you communicate, both online and offline, should align with the image you want to project. Whether in an interview, on social media or at a networking event, be mindful of how you present yourself and the impression you leave on others,” advises Read.

4 Enhancing your soft skills

Technical skills and academic knowledge are important, but soft skills – such as communication, teamwork and adaptability – often set candidates apart in the job market.



Many universities offer career services that include training in areas like resumé-writing, interview techniques and professional etiquette. These resources can be invaluable as you prepare to enter the workforce.

5 Preparing for the job search

As you approach graduation, it's important to start researching potential employers and industries that align with your career goals, says Read. Look for companies that match your skills and interests, share your values and offer opportunities for growth and development.

Next, spend time creating a professional resumé and portfolio that will stand out. Your resumé is often the first impression a potential employer has of you, so it's essential to make it count.

Then start preparing for the job search and interview, aware that this process is a job in itself. Set aside weekly time to search for job openings, tailor

“The transition from university to starting the job hunt and then landing your first role is daunting but can be made a little less so if you prepare properly.”

your application materials and follow up with employers. It's also a good idea to practise your interview skills with friends or at your higher education institution's career centre.

“Your university years aren't just about earning a degree – they're about laying the foundation for your future. By approaching your education with an eye towards your career, rather than waiting to cross that bridge until you get to it, you'll be well-equipped to navigate the challenges and seize the opportunities that await you in the world of work,” says Read.



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Fun and festive holiday treats

Chef and mom of four, Anri Fourie, shares these holiday treat recipes which are fun, festive and perfect for the whole family to make and enjoy!



Festive Rocky Road squares

Preparation time: 15 mins

Cooking time: 15 mins

Ingredients:

400g dark chocolate
200g unsalted butter
600g tennis or digestive biscuits, broken into pieces
300g mini-marshmallows

200g pecan nuts chopped
(Add dried cranberries for an extra Christmassy feel)

What else you will need:

A large mixing bowl
A knife and chopping board
A mixing spoon
A Pyrex glass tray
Spray and Cook
A heat-proof glass bowl

Method:

1. Melt chocolate and butter together in a heat-proof bowl in the microwave (heat for short bursts, with 40-second

intervals, stirring during each interval until smooth).

2. In a large mixing bowl, combine the broken biscuits, mini-marshmallows, nuts and cranberries.

3. Pour the melted chocolate mixture over the dry ingredients and stir until everything is well coated.





4. Set in a Pyrex bowl that has been sprayed with Spray and Cook.
5. Chill in the fridge for two hours.
6. Once set, cut into squares and enjoy.

Christmas chocolate brownie cookies

Preparation time: 15 mins

Cooking time: 10 mins

Ingredients:

- 125 ml (½ cup) unsalted butter
- 2 slabs dark chocolate (use milk chocolate, if preferred)
- 4 large eggs
- 500ml (2 cups) sugar
- 500ml (2 cups) cake flour

- 10ml (2 tsp) vanilla extract
- 2,5ml (½ tsp) salt
- 90ml (6T) cocoa powder
- 1,5ml (¼ tsp) baking powder
- Extra melted chocolate for decorating

What else you will need:

- A large mixing bowl
- A whisk or hand-mixer
- A small glass bowl suitable for a microwave
- A baking tray



- Spray and Cook
- A mixing spoon or spatula
- A teaspoon

Method:

1. Heat oven to 180°C.
2. Melt chocolate and butter together in a small microwave-safe bowl (melt in 30-second intervals, stirring during each interval until completely melted).
3. Allow to cool for 5 minutes.
4. While the chocolate is cooling, combine the sugar and eggs in a large bowl and whisk together well.
5. Add the cooled chocolate and mix well.
6. Fold in the flour, salt, cocoa powder and baking soda. Do not over-mix.
7. Use a teaspoon to scoop the cookie batter onto a baking tray prepared with Cook and Spray, leaving about 2cm around the edges for the cookies to spread.
8. Bake for 10 minutes.
9. Melt additional chocolate to cover cookies and decorate with festive sprinkles.



Anri Fourie, owner of two guesthouses and mom of a nine-year-old daughter and five-year-old triplets, cooks meals that are quick and easy to make – with multiple little helping hands. In the Fourie household, family time is a great time to cook together. As the former owner of a coffee shop, Anri used to share the kitchen with skilled chefs. Today she shares it with her four busy little offspring, who're all eager to pitch in and help.



In recent years, the approach to determining school-readiness has undergone significant changes



Is your child ready for big school?

Traditionally, school-readiness assessments in Grade 0 focused heavily on evaluating whether children met specific academic and developmental benchmarks. However, this method often overlooked the individual growth and unique strengths of each child. Today, there's been a shift towards a more holistic and supportive approach, emphasising continuous growth

and tailored support, says an education expert.

"The modern approach places less emphasis on traditional assessments and more on measuring and supporting pupil growth over time," says Lynda Eagle, Schools Academic Advisor at ADVTECH, Africa's leading private education provider.

"This shift recognises that each child develops at their own

pace and has unique strengths and areas for improvement. By focusing on growth, educators can better support pupils as they progress, extending their strengths and providing scaffolding, where needed."

The meaning of school-readiness

School-readiness is an assessment of the degree to which a child's prepared to enter school and succeed in a learning environment, explains Eagle.

When considering school-readiness there's a range of developmental areas – all inter-linked – that need to be considered: academic/cognitive, social, emotional and physical. Collectively, a healthy development across these areas will indicate that a child's ready and able to adapt and thrive in their new setting, she says.



“School-readiness isn’t just about knowledge. It involves a child’s ability to adapt, manage their emotions, positively interact with others and follow routines.”

Areas of development

Children’s development will differ according to their age and stage of development. The various elements considered are broadly defined as follows:

Physical: This includes both fine and gross motor skills that facilitate the child’s ability to control their body movements with increased accuracy and precision. The development of these skills ultimately prepares children for handwriting (letter and number formation) and more physical activities required when participating in sport, such as running, jumping and throwing, catching or hitting a ball.



Cognitive development: This is the ability of the child to process and demonstrate their understanding of foundational skills through problem-solving, the following of instructions, the sequencing of events and the ability to reason and apply what they’ve learnt to new situations.

Social development: This considers the child’s ability to interact

and collaborate with others, share and take turns. Do they understand social cues and are they able to interpret and respond appropriately to these, as well as recognise others’ emotions?

Emotional development: This involves the ability of the child to self-regulate and manage their emotions and behaviours. It facilitates the building of the child’s self-confidence and ability to work independently – to make sound choices and operate in a community effectively. In the case of gifted children, who may be intellectually advanced well beyond their age group, but not emotionally mature, parents need to be particularly aware of not prioritising academic achievements at the expense of the child’s social and psychological development. (See Supporting Gifted Children on p32.)



“Rather than ticking boxes to determine school-readiness, it’s our duty to focus on the child’s emotional, social and mental health – only once they feel safe will they be open to learning.”



She adds that parents and educators need to take a balanced approach by determining whether the school's ready for the child, and whether it can work with a framework that recognises the rights of the child by adapting and designing learning experiences that address gaps and challenges.

Beyond traditional assessments: Determining what's best for the child

"When we fail to consider the age and developmental stage of a child, we risk trying to grow or develop their skills before they're ready, or before they've had the necessary foundational experiences. This can have a lifetime impact if there's a rush towards achieving school-readiness," says Eagle.

"An over-emphasis on academic skills can lead to moving to abstract concepts without providing enough concrete experiences. Measuring and judging pupils against uniform pre-determined norms or standards means that there's a failure to recognise their unique needs, talents and dispositions. This approach places undue pressure on both the adults and the child to meet these milestones – often at the expense of developing important essential or soft skills."

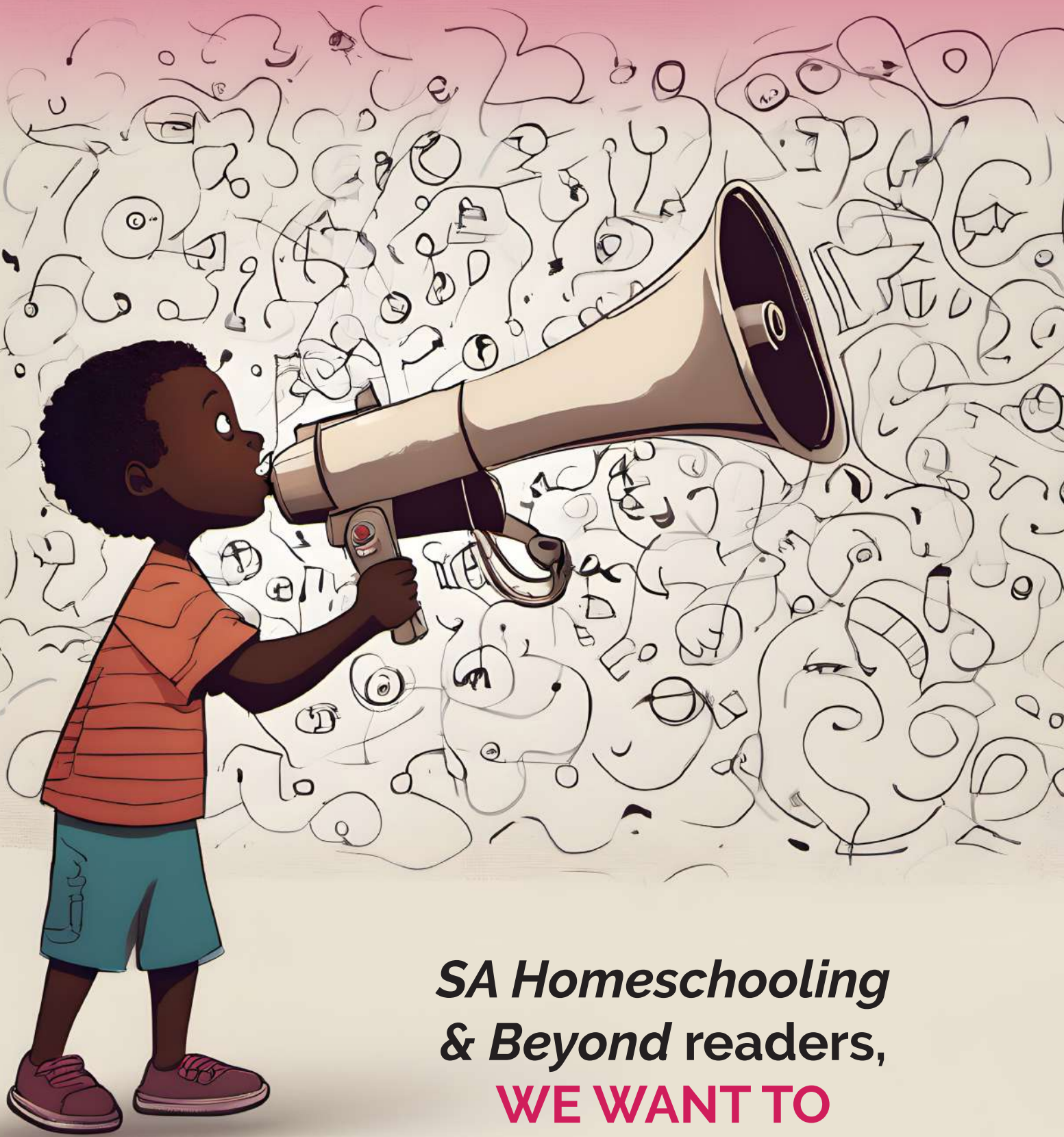


Additionally, failing to consider cultural contexts means that norms are based on standards that don't align with the child's unique experiences.

"Fostering a competitive environment can place pressure on a child's well-being, sense of belonging and identity. When a child's labelled as not ready, it implies that they're unworthy, leading to judgement, rather than nurturing," cautions Eagle.

"Rather than ticking boxes to determine school-readiness, it's our duty to focus on the child's emotional, social and mental health – only once they feel safe will they be open to learning. We must be flexible and adaptive, as well as inclusive and affirmative in our actions and behaviours – as well as in the language we use. The overriding recognition should be that children don't mature or learn in the same ways. That's as it should be and simply requires us to adjust accordingly," says Eagle.

"The overriding recognition should be that children don't mature or learn in the same ways. That's as it should be and simply requires us to adjust accordingly."



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Craft ideas to stimulate right-brain development

Arts and crafts play a vital role in children's early development, particularly in stimulating the right hemisphere of the brain, which is responsible for creativity, imagination and emotional expression

For young children aged six and under, engaging in arts and crafts not only nurtures their artistic skills, but introduces them to the rich cultural and natural diversity of their surroundings.

"Engaging children in arts and crafts from a young age is essential for their cognitive and emotional growth," says Ursula Assis, Country Director of Dibber International Preschools. "These activities help them develop fine motor skills, spatial awareness and an appreciation of the beauty around them, fostering a lifelong love of creativity and learning."

Here are some age-appropriate arts and crafts ideas designed to foster creativity and cognitive

growth, while celebrating South Africa's unique heritage:

1 Nature collage: Take a leisurely stroll through a local park or garden, gathering leaves, flowers and small pebbles. Back at home, transform these natural treasures into collages on sturdy paper or cardboard. This hands-on activity encourages children to explore textures and shapes, while developing fine motor skills as they arrange and glue down their creations.

2 Cardboard box creations: Unleash creativity by repurposing cardboard boxes into imaginative

structures such as castles, forts or vehicles. Using simple art supplies like markers, stickers or paints, children can personalise their creations, fostering spatial awareness and problem-solving skills through play.

3 Paper plate masks:

Explore South Africa's cultural richness by crafting masks inspired by local animals or traditional designs, using paper plates and safe craft materials. Decorating these masks with paint, feathers or yarn encourages imaginative role-play, while introducing children to different cultural elements in a fun and interactive way.



Salt dough shapes: Mix

4 flour, salt and water to create pliable salt dough. Guide children in shaping the dough into animals or simple sculptures, which can be air-dried and painted afterwards.

This tactile experience enhances sensory exploration and creativity, allowing children to express themselves through three-dimensional art.

5 Recycled art collage:

Promote environmental stewardship by collecting recyclable materials like cardboard tubes, bottle caps and egg cartons. Help children create collages or sculptures by arranging and glueing these items onto paper or cardboard, fostering creativity while instilling a sense of responsibility for the environment.

6 Bubble-wrap printing:

Transform ordinary bubble-wrap into a printing tool by dipping it into non-toxic paint and pressing it onto paper. This sensory-rich activity not only introduces children to different textures, but allows them to

create unique patterns and designs, stimulating artistic exploration and experimentation.

7 **Found-object art:** Go on outdoor adventures to collect natural objects such as seashells, unusually shaped twigs or ferns. Then, back indoors, use these found treasures to create simple artworks or patterns on paper, encouraging children to appreciate the beauty of nature, while expressing themselves artistically.

8 Easy origami and paper crafts:

Introduce children to the ancient art of origami or simple paper crafts using colourful paper. From folding animals to crafting bookmarks or greeting cards, these activities enhance fine motor skills and spatial awareness, while providing endless opportunities for creative expression.



Supporting gifted children

Nicola Killops, a specialist in gifted education and a passionate advocate of neurodiversity, has witnessed first-hand the struggles that parents of gifted children face within our education system

Killops believes that despite their remarkable potential, gifted children are often underserved and misunderstood and says it's time to change that narrative and give them the support they deserve.

Understanding giftedness

Giftedness is frequently misconceived as merely high academic achievement. However, it encompasses a broader spectrum of abilities, including exceptional creativity, advanced problem-solving skills and natural leadership qualities. The US National Association for Gifted Children defines a gifted pupil as someone who "demonstrates outstanding aptitude in one or more areas". The UK takes a similar view, with its Department for Education

describing gifted pupils as those who achieve or have the potential to achieve significantly above average in both academic and non-academic fields.

These may include:

- **Rapid mastery of basic skills:** Gifted children often learn new concepts and skills much faster than their peers.



- **Advanced reading ability and extensive vocabulary:** Many gifted children read at levels far beyond their age group and possess a rich vocabulary.
- **Intellectual curiosity:** They frequently ask probing questions and seek more profound understanding.



- **Emotional intensity:** Gifted children often experience emotions more intensely, which can lead to heightened sensitivity and anxiety.
- **Strong sense of ethics and values:** They may show a keen awareness of fairness and justice from a young age.



Understanding these traits is crucial for parents and educators, as it helps to create an environment that nurtures gifted children's unique needs.

What gifted children need

Gifted children thrive in settings that offer personalised learning, enrichment opportunities and mentorship. They benefit immensely from interacting with like-minded peers and adults who understand and appreciate their unique perspectives.

Key components that support the development of gifted children include:

- **Personalised learning:** Tailoring educational experiences to match their advanced learning pace and interests is essential. This can involve differentiated instruction, curriculum compacting and acceleration.
- **Enrichment opportunities:** Gifted children need access to challenging projects, advanced coursework and opportunities to explore their interests in depth. Programmes that provide intellectual stimulation can help prevent disengagement and under-achievement.
- **Social interaction:** Opportunities to connect with peers with similar interests can foster a sense of belonging and help develop social skills.



“Tailoring educational experiences to match their advanced learning pace and interests is essential.”



Gifted children often feel isolated, so creating a supportive community is vital.

- **Mentorship:** Guidance from mentors who understand the unique challenges and strengths of gifted children can provide invaluable support, helping them navigate their educational journeys.

Twice-exceptional (2E) children

Twice-exceptional (2E) children are those who are gifted, yet also face learning disabilities or other challenges. This group is often even more underserved,

as their unique needs can be overlooked in traditional educational settings. Many 2E children find themselves in remedial programmes that don't cater to their giftedness, leading to a mismatch that can hinder their potential and result in frustration and under-achievement.

Supporting 2E children requires a nuanced approach that recognises their gifts and challenges. Individual education plans can be instrumental in providing the tailored support they need, ensuring their

educational experiences are enriching and accommodating.

The importance of enrichment

Enrichment goes beyond the standard curriculum; it provides gifted children with the intellectual stimulation they crave. This includes challenging projects, advanced coursework and opportunities to delve deeply into their interests. Without such enrichment, gifted children can become disengaged and under-perform, despite their high potential.

The consequences of unmet needs

When the educational needs of gifted children aren't holistically met, the repercussions can be severe. These children may experience low self-esteem, under-achievement and social isolation. We must address these unmet needs to foster an environment where they can thrive and

realise their full potential. In short, the overlooked potential of gifted children calls for a collective effort to reshape our educational landscape. By recognising their unique needs and providing tailored support, we can ensure that these remarkable young individuals are understood and empowered to excel in their pursuits.

SA's Department of Basic Education recognises that gifted pupils require tailored educational experiences to thrive. However, significant obstacles to implementing effective programmes for these pupils include policy gaps, lack of teacher training and severely limited resources, as well as inability on the part of both parents and teachers to recognise their giftedness.

In inclusive classrooms, a one-size-fits-all approach often leaves gifted children feeling unchallenged and disengaged. This can lead to frustration,

under-achievement and a negative impact on their self-esteem and motivation. This may cause them to act out in negative ways.

A holistic approach

Gershon Aitchison holds a Harvard Certificate in Advanced Educational Leadership and is the principal at Education Incorporated, a specialised Johannesburg school. "Gifted children need more than academic challenges – they need emotional and social support tailored to their unique experiences. Our approach ensures that each child is understood and nurtured holistically," he says.

Jacqueline Aitchison, founder and Executive Head of Education Incorporated, as well as Head of Professional Development for the Southern African Heads of Independent Schools Association: Central Region, adds: "We focus on creating an environment where gifted children can explore their interests deeply, engage in critical thinking and develop essential life skills. This approach supports not only their academic growth, but their emotional and social well-being."





Why kids need boredom more than ever

As the year winds down, many parents find themselves focused on two things: making it through the last stretch of the school year and planning how to keep the kids busy over the long December break. However, Dalena van der Westhuizen, cognitive development specialist, executive function skills coach and co-owner of BrainAbility, reminds us of a surprising alternative – embracing boredom



There's a powerful alternative to the endless line-up of holiday activities, planned outings and screen time: boredom. Far from being an enemy, boredom is a gift that allows children of all ages to develop critical skills. It can play a vital role in helping children develop essential life skills, encouraging creativity, patience and resilience in ways that structured activities often can't.

Boredom fosters creativity and imagination

Research shows that when children are left with “nothing to do”, they're actually given an opportunity to create. With no structured activities or screens to entertain them, they're more likely to invent games and engage in make-believe adventures or new activities. According to a study published in the *Academy of Management Journal*, boredom prompts people to seek novelty, which leads to more creative ideas. Whether toddlers or teenagers, unstructured time allows youngsters to dive deep into their imagination and become their own source of entertainment.

Learning self-regulation and patience One often overlooked benefit of boredom is the way it helps children develop patience. When a child faces boredom and works through it independently, they learn to handle feelings of restlessness and self-regulate emotions. This ability to tolerate and work through low-stimulation situations is crucial



for building executive function skills, such as impulse control and emotional resilience. Researchers at the UK's University of Central Lancashire suggest that this self-regulation skill helps young people develop patience, an important attribute in school, work and social relationships.

Boredom encourages

problem-solving skills From toddlers constructing towers to teens exploring new hobbies, problem-solving skills thrive in moments of downtime. Left to themselves, children often find ways to self-entertain, whether through games, exploring the outdoors or diving into a new creative project. The absence of scheduled activities encourages them to think critically about how to spend their time, helping them develop resourcefulness and adaptability.

Boredom improves mental health and reduces stress

For teenagers, in particular, a break from the demands of school and social life can be a mental reset. Free, unstructured time gives them the opportunity to reflect and decompress, offering mental clarity and reducing stress. Studies published by *Psychology Today* reveal that downtime allows the brain to consolidate memories and recharge. High school and tertiary students, in particular,



“While the December holidays may tempt us to pack our calendar with activities, remember that it’s okay to let children be bored.”

often lead fast-paced lives and the chance to pause can enhance their well-being and give them a renewed sense of focus and motivation.

Encouraging a healthy relationship with technology

In today's digital world, children



are rarely without electronic devices and boredom is often managed with a screen. However, extended time without structured activities can encourage kids to rediscover non-digital sources of joy. A balanced relationship with technology becomes easier when children have developed hobbies and interests they can turn to beyond their devices.

The take-away While the December holidays may tempt us to pack our calendar with activities, remember that it's okay to let children be bored. Allowing them these hours, free from constant stimulation, offers growth in creativity, patience, mental health and much more. Embracing boredom as a natural part of life gives our children space to learn, explore and thrive in ways that structured activities can't always offer.

Academic success is becoming more critical than ever in the current economic environment, as competition for jobs and higher education access grows increasingly intense

Parental involvement can significantly enhance a child's academic performance, according to an education expert.

"As parents, we're pivotal in nurturing an environment that fosters learning and growth, so we should – especially in the foundational years – ensure that our children are given the correct support to mould and cement their approach to their educational journey," says Dr Linda Meyer, MD at IIE Rosebank College.

She says parents who're serious about supporting their child's learning journey can put the following framework in place:

1 Create a positive environment "The home environment is where a child's learning journey truly begins.



Boost your child's academic performance



Creating a space conducive to studying is essential," says Meyer.

"A positive learning environment also extends to the emotional atmosphere at home. Encourage open communication, celebrate achievements and approach challenges with a problem-solving mindset. Children who feel supported are more likely to be motivated and engaged in their studies."

2 Foster a love of learning Academic success isn't just about grades: it's also about cultivating a lifelong love

of learning. Children's academic performance will naturally improve when learning is a joy, rather than a chore.

"Encourage your child's natural curiosity by exploring subjects that interest them beyond the classroom. Whether reading books, visiting museums or engaging in science experiments at home, fostering a sense of wonder and excitement about learning can help children develop a passion for knowledge," says Meyer.

“The home environment is where a child’s learning journey truly begins. Creating a space conducive to studying is essential.”

3 Keep it real While encouraging your children to strive for excellence is essential, setting realistic expectations is equally important.

“High pressure can lead to stress and burnout, which are detrimental to academic performance. Work with your child to set achievable goals and break them into manageable tasks. Celebrate milestones along the way, no matter how small. This approach builds confidence and teaches valuable time management and organisational skills,” she says.

4 Be actively involved Meyer emphasises that active parental involvement is a cornerstone of academic success. This is why attending parent-teacher conferences, monitoring homework and staying informed about your child’s progress is important.



“Engage in regular discussions about what they’re learning at school and show interest in their assignments. When parents are actively involved, children are more likely to take their studies seriously and strive to meet the expectations set for them,” she says.

5 Encourage critical thinking and problem-solving Critical thinking is a vital skill that extends beyond the classroom. Encourage your child to think critically by asking open-ended questions and discussing various topics and perspectives.

“Teaching your child to approach challenges analytically will equip them with the tools they need to excel academically and in life,” says Meyer.

6 Be a role model Children often mirror the behaviours and attitudes of their parents, so we should model enthusiasm for learning and intellectual curiosity in our own lives.

“Whether reading books, discussing current events or pursuing a hobby, demonstrating a commitment to personal growth can inspire your child to adopt similar attitudes towards their education and life in general,” explains Meyer.

Academic success is closely linked to emotional well-being, so it’s also important to encourage your child to develop strong social skills and emotional intelligence, she adds.





Choosing the right school for your child



Your child's school experience sets them up for life, so it's crucial to choose the right one. Lindy du Preez, Achievement Manager at SPARK Schools, offers advice to parents who're in the process of choosing a school for their children – whether it's a traditional one or online

"A child's educational experience, from the very beginning, plays a vital part in their lives and will determine their academic, social and (probably) occupational success. So, when it comes to choosing a school (whether it's a traditional or online one) which will assist in raising well-rounded and productive adults with a positive future, parents need to choose a school which best meets the current – and future – needs of their children," says Du Preez.

She advises parents to consider the following before choosing a school:



Teaching and learning approaches:

The future is literally digital, so a school which emphasises technology training is crucial. Seek out schools that use a blended learning model where there's split time between technology-based learning (which can be adapted to the learning pace of the pupil) and direct classroom instruction. Ask

whether the school uses data-driven instruction, because this is the best way for teachers to know exactly where pupils are in their academic progress. Children today are incredibly tech-savvy and by integrating technology



into the classroom, teachers are not only changing the way they teach, but giving pupils critical tools to forge meaningful futures in the 21st century.

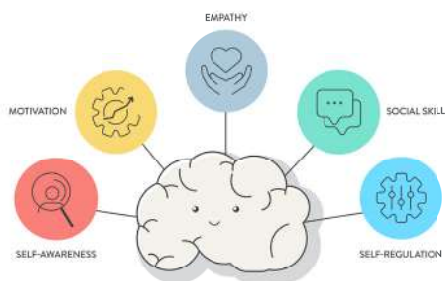
Values and vision: Find a school which upholds the values you want to instil in your child (eg persistence, responsibility, kindness), as well as a vision that's bigger than the school itself. The school you choose should have values that help children become responsible global citizens who're equally aware of the opportunities and responsibilities before them.

Cost matters: The affordability of a school is one of the first things parents think about when it comes to making their selection. However, a common mistake is associating expensive fees with quality outcomes. Do your research. There are many new private schools providing quality education and outcomes at a price point comparable with many government schools. Excellent, affordable education for your child is within your reach.

A holistic approach: While academic results matter a lot, other skills such as empathy, resilience, collaboration and emotional intelligence are equally needed. Find a school whose teaching methods, curriculum and general operations have an impact on the development



of a child and are invested in developing all-round human beings. Developing a child's emotional and social skills is not only crucial for them to achieve success, but is important in developing a person who can contribute meaningfully to society. These soft skills are increasingly important in the workplace and a child who has them will thrive in the new world of work.



Excellence recognised: Again, doing your own research is important. What sort of reputation does the school have? Is it a leader in its field – recognised locally and globally? Does it

“It’s important for parents to choose a school that will best meet the current and future needs of their children.”

embrace best-practice teaching methods? Your child faces a constantly changing world where innovation and best practices in education will set them up to cope with change and thrive.

“I urge parents to visit schools on their open days and ask lots of questions to ensure their child’s needs are met. Knowledge is power. Schools engage with youngsters during the most important years of their lives, so it’s important for parents to choose one that will best meet the current and future needs of their children,” says Du Preez.

Google unveils School Time

Google has announced School Time, a new feature for Android phones and other devices designed to reduce distractions for children during school hours

School Time was developed in response to parents' feedback on how to control screen time for their children. It aims to balance the need for children to focus on schoolwork with the importance of staying connected, in case of emergencies.

School Time allows parents to set a dedicated home screen with limited functionality on their child's personal device during school hours, helping to reduce distractions during class. Parents can schedule and select which apps are permitted during School Time using Family

Link, Google's parental control app. They can also choose to allow calls or texts from specific contacts.

"Parents think deeply about how their children should use technology, including how to strike the right balance between online and offline time. We're continuously investing in research and development to address the evolving needs of parents and children. By collaborating closely with experts in child development, education and technology, our goal is to help shape a future where technology continues to facilitate learning and exploration," says Siya Madikane, Communications Manager.

School Time can also be turned on or off outside of class, when it's time to focus or take a break from screens. For teens who aren't supervised by a parent through Family Link, Focus mode on Android devices prevents notifications and limits distractions during specific periods. The feature's also been introduced on Fitbit Ace LTE smartwatches. Over the next year, Google will be bringing the feature to more devices, including select Android phones, tablets and Samsung Galaxy watches to promote a productive learning environment.

The tailored settings on the tool include new supervision features for parents of teens joining YouTube. This will allow parents



and teens to link their accounts, enabling parents to gain visibility of their teens' YouTube activity. As children transition into adolescence, parents may want different supervision options to better reflect their teens' understanding and use of technology.

Recognising this, Google is allowing parents to select settings that can be used in a family to differentiate by age, developmental stage and parenting style. Parents will be able to determine the apps, products and experiences their teens can use. Additionally, they'll

"We're continuously investing in research and development to address the evolving needs of parents and children."

be able to monitor their children's activities and set digital ground rules like screen time limits or location-sharing.

Lastly, default safety settings have been put in place for users under the age of 18. This includes turning SafeSearch on, implementing content restrictions and turning autoplay off on YouTube. "We've introduced new safeguards that limit recommendations of videos with content that could be problematic, especially for teens, if viewed in repetition – such as content related to body image," says Madikane.



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